

NZ CPI preview, March quarter 2026

#inflation

#newzealand



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We estimate NZ consumer prices rose 0.7% in the March quarter, leaving them 2.8% higher over the past year. However, prices are set to soar over 4% later this year.



 [Read full report here \(PDF 394KB\)](#)

Calm-ish before the storm

- We estimate that New Zealand consumer prices rose by 0.7% in the March quarter. That's slightly lower than our previous forecast, reflecting updated information from Stats NZ's monthly prices report.
- The annual inflation rate is expected to dip to 2.8% (from 3.1% previously).
- But while the annual inflation rate is set to soften a little in March, this will be just a temporary reprieve. Inflation is set to rise sharply through the middle part of the year in response to the recent rise in oil prices and related increase in other costs. We expect inflation will rise to around 4.3% mid-year.
- March's lift in consumer prices is mainly due to higher prices for food and petrol.
- Under the surface, core inflation is expected to remain at firm levels.
- Our forecast is close to the RBNZ's updated forecast for 3.0% annual inflation.

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